an exhibition, "Eight American Artists," that was sponsored by the United States Information Agency and traveled through Europe and Asia. In 1961, Tobey became the first American to exhibit at the Musée des Arts Décoratifs (Palais du Louvre, Paris). This was followed with other retrospectives including those at the Museum of Modern Art (New York, 1962), Dallas Museum of Art (1968), Seattle Art Museum (1970), Smithsonian Institution's National Collection of Fine Arts (1974), National Gallery of Art in Washington, D.C. (1994), and the Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía (Madrid, Spain, 1997). (Conkelton, 1999: 43)

Tobey was born in Centerville, Wisconsin, in 1890 and grew up in the Midwest. When his family moved near Chicago, he began attending Saturday watercolor and oils classes at the Art Institute of Chicago. In his youth, Tobey held a succession of different jobs, including work as a blueprint boy in a steel mill and eventually as an errand boy for a fashion studio. Tobey's early artistic influences were from the commercial illustrations of Harrison Fisher, Howard Chandler Christy, and Charles Dana Gibson. He did not complete a formal education. In 1911, Tobey moved to New York's Greenwich Village in order to pursue a career as a fashion illustrator. During this time, he also did portraits, which were shown at a New York gallery and garnered his first critical recognition.

In 1918, Tobey converted to the Bahá'í World Faith, a universalist belief system. For the rest of his life, his thinking and work were supported and infused by its philosophy, which is based upon three premises of unity, "progressive revelation," and humanity. (Dahl, 1984: 15)

By the early 1920s, Tobey was recognized for his "caricatures of theatrical people," (some published in *New York Times*) and drawings of vaudeville and burlesque personalities. Following a brief and unhappy marriage in 1922, and due to "growing social demands," he decided to move from New York. He caught a train with a friend of his who was returning to Seattle.

He accepted a teaching position at the Cornish School in Seattle, then a new and progressive school attracting national and international faculty and visiting artists. He taught at Cornish until 1931. During this time, Tobey experienced his own "personal discovery of Cubism," which led to the "moving focus and linear trajectory" of his later white writing. In 1923, he met Teng Kuei, a Chinese artist studying at the University of Washington. They became good friends. It was from Teng that Tobey "learned both [the] technique and philosophy of Chinese calligraphy."

In 1925, Tobey left for Europe, spending several months in Paris before accompanying friends in 1926 to Spain, Greece, Turkey and Lebanon. At this time, he also made his first visit to Bahá'í Shrines and World Centre at Haifa. Over the course of the following three years, Tobey spent his time "teaching, experimenting, and painting" in Seattle, New York, and Chicago.

In 1931, he was offered a six-month appointment at Dartington Hall (Devonshire, England), which turned into an eight-year stay. During this time, he traveled again to Europe and the Bahá'í World Centre in 1932. In 1934 he accompanied Bernard Leach, a renowned British ceramist, to Hong Kong where they spent a week before separating. Tobey went to Shanghai to spend time with Teng before continuing on to Japan, where he spent a month in a monastery. It was following this trip, and due to the influence of his interest in cities--their energy, people, and light--that his mature style began to emerge, as seen in *Broadway Norm*, *Broadway* (1936), and *Welcome Hero*. In 1938, he returned to Seattle working at first on a New Deal art project and teaching. (Dahl, 1984: 2-9)